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CREATING BLOOD DONORS AT HOME

A leitmotif among blood donation organisations is the increasing difficulty in finding people with “generous veins”; and the solution could strangely be found in the living rooms of households, as illustrated by these two accounts from Chennai **P4&5**



REELS AND WHEELS

Here is how N. Senbagavalli, a BOV operator with Urbaser Sumeet in the morning and an autodriver in the evening, became the face of the algorithm **P6**



▼ The plants at the GCC park on MGR Road in Kalakshetra colony: now and (right) in the past.

varieties of plants and trees, crowned by the mandaraai, magnificent in its season. You can walk your chosen number of steps under its canopy of green. Quite often on a humid evening you can catch a delicious breeze as you turn at the southwest corner, despite the encircling buildings. For a time, you can ignore the whine and grind of encroaching construction sites nearby.

Bharati's account continues: “Sprinklers were installed some months ago but they do not work properly. The workers damaged parts of the walkers’ track while doing this and did not carry out repairs despite numerous com-

plaints. The walls were repainted some months ago but not the benches which badly need a fresh coat of paint.” Anyone who has rubbed shoulders with KCWA members is likely to have heard about what the park sprung from: “a rubbish dump salvaged and converted into a green space by a few civic minded residents, notably the late Mr. Krishnamoorthy who lived next door.”

KCWA has been taking a keen interest in the park's maintenance, trouble shooting whenever needed, taking the issues for resolution to the local Corporation official, and sometimes, escalating matters to the councillor of Ward 179.

At the time of this article going to print, a local Corporation official told *The Hindu Downtown* the issue pertaining to the sprinklers will be resolved soon.

Plea to help ‘wilting’ plants

PRINCE FREDERICK

At Kalakshetra Colony in Thiruvannamiyur, the sun is expected not to set on this park and let it fade into oblivion. This instead meant to stay evergreen simply on account of its location, if not anything else.

It is tucked squarely into the intersection of two roads named af-

ter two evergreen heroes of Tamil Nadu politics. This park in Ward 179 is located at the point where Karunanidhi Road meets MGR Road. While those leaders’ memory is hallowed and stays evergreen and fresh, the park connected with their memory indirectly is losing its green.

On the evening of July 17, when *The Hindu Downtown* made a visit to the park, at the behest of a re-

presentative of Kalakshetra Colony Welfare Association (KCWA), the sprinklers turned on, as if on cue. These sprinklers were in the skies and not on the ground. It started raining, heavily, accelerating to hundred the way those beastly supercars do. The sprinklers on the ground however were unmoved; and going by MGR Road resident and KCWA executive committee member Bharati Sadasivam’s account of their performance in recent months, they are “sedentary” or erratic.

Some sprinklers do not work, and those that do, function ineffectively, pooling water in just one area: that is Bharati’s performance appraisal report for the sprinklers. Here are Bharati’s thoughts, reproduced verbatim, about what the park means to residents of Kalakshetra Colony and what has become of the park now with particular reference to the health of its plants.

“This modest walkers’ park is a green refuge for those of us who frequent it mornings or evenings. It is the only one of its kind for miles around, with more than 25

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Exploration of green campuses in Chennai soon

With a pan-India initiative by Nature Conservation Foundation inviting colleges to create a Campus Biodiversity Register, one can find lists from institutions such as MCC, IIT-M, WCC and Stella Maris making it to iNaturalist, eBird and Season Watch



The sylvan MCC campus.

LIFFY THOMAS

The backyard of certain college campuses hardly resemble backyards as we usually understand them: a poky little space, lacklustre, hardly hoofed by human feet. In these colleges, the backyard is an expansive space, supporting an incredible population of furs and feathers; and they pull in human feet given to exploration and documentation of biodiversity.

Classic examples include IIT Madras in Guindy and Madras Christian College in Tambaram. There are also others such as Women's Christian College in Nungambakkam and Stella Maris College in Gopalapuram that lend themselves to making of biodiversity checklists.

Against this green backdrop, Campus Biodiversity Register (CBS) is hugely relevant to Chennai. CBS invites colleges and universities to discover and document the biodiversity on their campuses and build a lasting record of it. An initiative of the Nature on Campus team of the Nature Conservation Foundation (NCF) together with the National Biodiversity Authority, Government of India, the nationwide year-long initiative seeks that students and faculty document biodiversity on their campuses using three citizen science platforms – iNaturalist, eBird and SeasonWatch. WCC, Stella Maris and MCC have doc-

umented the flora, avifauna and fauna on their campuses in the past and brought books on them. From some colleges, the books have also opened their pages to insects. Students of the BSc in Environmental Science and Sustainability and teachers at Azim Premji University in Bengaluru brought out a Campus Biodiversity Register 2024-25 that can be accessed online.

CBR expects these institutions to document their biodiversity with conservation in mind, sustaining endangered species. Besides gaining hands-on experience observing, identifying and documenting species, the participating institutions would be contributing to a global database with their inputs. According to a note on campusbiodiversity.in, by participating one is contributing valuable biodiversity information to global databases as envisioned by the Convention on Biological Diversity while complementing the efforts of the People's Biodiversity Register. The project encourages institutions with just standalone buildings to also sign up for the exercise as biodiversity can be found in the most unexpected places.

There is no fee to participate in this project. Registrations are open till November 2026.

For more details, visit <https://campusbiodiversity.in> or email natureoncampus@ncf-india.org

(MVBB), based in Gopalapuram and run by TTK Group as a service to society, and whenever he receives a call-up from them, he is in attendance at that address the next moment. In April this year, MVBB celebrated its Golden Jubilee.

Shamsudeen elaborates: "As I have a rare blood type, I do not donate blood once in three to four months as many donors do, but donate when there is an emergency, an urgent need for AB Negative. MVBB keeps a record of when I donated blood, and in an emergency, they would call me if I am within the date for donating blood again."

Bookmark this thought: irrespective of whether one's blood group is rare or common, one would do well to be attached to a blood donation organisation so that one gets tuned in to the idea of donating blood as often as they can by virtue of getting timely reminders and urgent call-ups.

Shamsudeen's blood donation tally stands at 22.

As he desired, Shamsudeen's journey as a blood donor has followed the same trajectory as his father's.

(Before proceeding with the how of it, a snapshot of a recent ho-

If you are gripped by a mission to increase the numbers of blood donors, but do not know where to begin, begin at home. Have conversations with your children about your blood donation journey. It sure works: ask the Shaikhs

A leitmotif among blood donation organisations is the increasing difficulty in finding people with "generous veins"; and the solution could strangely be found in the living rooms of households, as illustrated by these two accounts from Chennai of parents inspiring their children to join the cause

Create blood donors at home

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN



Shaikh Shamsudeen and Shaikh Sadaqathullah

nour to the father-son duo. Last month, on World Blood Donors Day, Crescent Blood Donors honoured Shaikh Sadaqathullah and his son Shaikh Shamsudeen for their commitment to blood donation at an event organised at Kavikko Convention Centre in Mylapore. The award was jointly presented by noted film director Ameer Sultan and Ahmed Buhari, trustee of B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology)

Besides the commitment to donating blood as often they can and the choice to be attached to MVBB, father and son share their blood type, AB Negative. The blood donation tally of Shaikh Sadaqathullah, 56 years old, stands at 53. As Sadaqathullah notes, a tinge of disappointment slipping into his voice for a fleeting moment, he stopped donating blood due to health concerns.

(A trivia: Sadaqathullah is an amateur radio operator and his call sign is VU2SDU)

Sadaqathullah's blood donation journey was initiated at the Perambur Railway Hospital in 1993 where he donated blood responding to a friend's call. "It was then I realised that my blood group was rare. Any negative blood type is considered rare, and AB Negative is rare even among the negative blood types. Globally, 2 per cent of the population has this blood type. Given this, I have not donated at blood donation camps, only when there was an emergency need for AB Negative, and MVBB would call him."

The interviews were with the father and son duo were conducted separately, and what struck was the similarity not only in the language they used, but also the sentiments they expressed.

There is a lesson there, and probably hope too, for blood donation champions such as Srivatsa Vema from the Federation of Indian Blood Donors Organisation (FIBDO) who has expressed concern over a decreasing number of blood donors.

Bookmark this thought too: if you gripped by a mission to increase the numbers of blood donors, but do not know where to begin, begin at home. Have conversations with your children about your blood donation journey. It sure works: ask the Shaikhs.

COLLECTIVE KINDNESS is a column about efforts by voluntary agencies and individual volunteers to shore up processes by public and private enterprises aimed at bringing personal well-being to people

Get started

There are many organisations that drive blood donation on an everyday basis and also through campaigns. Here are some organisations that can help one get started on blood donation.

- Rotary Central TTK VHS Blood Bank being run at Voluntary Health Services (VHS) in Tharamani. Contact: 044-22542829
- Madras Voluntary Blood Bank (MVBB) at 6, Cathedral Road in Gopalapuram, organises blood donations for people in need, connecting donors with those who need blood. Contact: 9841821997/ 9094039538 / 044-28111403 (Saturday and Sunday are off days)
- Crescent Blood Donors at Crescent college campus in Vandalur. Though located at an institution, outsiders can also donate blood after being screened; the group can be contacted for blood donation needs too. Contact: 9087410874
- Through blood donation drives, New College supports blood bank at government hospitals as well as individuals looking for blood donors. The college does not have a dedicated blood bank, but its administrative office can be contacted at 044-28351269/ 28350386
- For donating blood and to receive blood as donation, contact Federation of Indian Blood Donors at 9381005254
- Direction for Volunteers (D4V) conducts blood donation drives and its efforts help medical establishments such as Voluntary Health Services and Institute of Child Health. For details, WhatsApp D4V at 7448888065
- Lions Blood Bank & Research Foundation is located at 130, Marshalls Road in Egmore. For details, call 044-28414949

A family tradition



R. Ravikumar donating blood on March 17, 2026 for the 106th time.

Nanganallur resident R. Ravikumar would not skip certain schedules, some day-based and others occurring every few months, not for all the tea in China. These schedules largely relate to his passion for cycling, running and donating blood. The unwavering commitment to blood donation has put an enviable tally against his name: 106 blood donations, the last donation made on March 17, 2026 at Sunrays Hospital in Ashok Nagar.

Ravikumar, a retired manager from the Oriental Insurance Company Limited, has never viewed blood donation as a mere act of charity. It has been a family legacy, a service that brings him closer to his father's memory: his father was a blood donor, having donated over 50 times in his lifetime. And Ravikumar traces his iron-clad commitment to blood donation to his late father S. Rengarajan's example as well as simple philosophy, which drives his world view. "Even if we cannot help someone financially, we can always serve the society through our actions without expecting anything in return," his father would often say. Inspired by those words, Ravikumar (whose blood type is B Positive) began do-

nating blood at the age of 23 in 1984, the first donation aimed at helping a colleague's wife who was undergoing surgery. To continue this service, Ravikumar has made staying healthy his top priority through regular marathon runs and long distance cycling, believing physical fitness is the reason that he is still able to answer every call for blood.

Since the age of 56, he has participated in numerous endurance events, earning 85 medals. He is also an active member of several blood donation groups in Chennai, continuing to respond to urgent need for donors.

Among the 106 donations, one will always remain etched in his memory. In 2019, after donating blood for a six-year-old cancer patient from Odisha, the child's parents insisted on meeting him. "I told them I had done nothing special, but they still wanted to thank me," he recalls.

The scene that followed will make anyone go teary-eyed. They bowed in gratitude, a gesture that deeply moved him and reaffirmed his belief that compassion knows no language.

While Ravikumar's father donated blood over 50 times, and today his brother R. Ramesh has crossed 60 donations.

What began as one man's quiet belief in selfless service has now grown into a powerful family tradition.

The list of hospitals Ravikumar has donated to include Apollo Hospital in Greams Road, Nandanam Apollo Cancer Speciality Hospital, Vijaya Hospital, Miot Hospital, Egmore Children's Hospital, Adyar Cancer Institute, VHS Blood Bank, various Rotary Club camps, Railway Hospital in Perambur, Sevayala in Thirunindravoor, SIMS Hospital, Chrompet Government Hospital, Rajaji Government Hospital, Sunrays Hospital and WCCG blood donation camps.

Ravikumar is 65 years old now, usually considered the maximum age at which one could donate blood. Exceptions to that rule do exist; and Ravikumar seems set to be an exception.

Reels and wheels

Here is how N. Senbagavalli, a BOV operator with Urbaser Sumeet in the morning and an autodriver in the evening, became the face of the algorithm

LIFFY THOMAS

Pallikaranai resident N. Senbagavalli is an overnight Internet sensation. Just six months into Instagram, she has managed a following, modest by influencer standards but huge for most Insta users. At last look, sanbagavalli_reels_queen (her Insta page) had 17.2k followers.

As she dances to Tamil film hits, nobody can deny she has rhythm. Another factor enabling her reels to stand out: she is dressed as a conservancy worker. This is not reel, but real life. She is a conservancy worker with Urbaser Sumeet. And an autodriver in the evening. And a digital creator in between.

"Dancing has been a childhood

passion and I derive joy from juggling various roles," says Senbagavalli, attached to Zone XIV of Greater Chennai Corporation as conservancy worker for the last 13 years. She developed an interest in dancing as a child when she would accompany her mother to the latter's workplace, AVM Studios. "At the Studios, when shoots were on, I would watch every dance move from a distance to pick up a step or two," says the school dropout. She even got to be a background dancer in a song in Prashanth starrer *Thiruda Thiruda*.

Marriage and motherhood meant dance could not be central to her life; but only for a while. Her husband, working as a security guard, has always encouraged her,



N. Senbagavalli is responsible for collecting waste from Kamakoti Nagar in Pallikaranai.

and that explains the impressive output of Insta reels now.

She started sharing dance videos on Tik Tok. After Tik Tok was banned in India, she took to YouTube and now Instagram, her sister's daughter helping her open an account.

"I cannot read; somehow I have learnt to scroll through posts and share videos. Sometimes it is my two sons who translate the comments shared after each post, which really motivates me to explore the dancer in me," says Senbagavalli, adding that many residents in Kamakoti Nagar, where she makes trips to collect waste, are aware of her love for dance. The Pallikaranai resident is thrilled when she gets to showcase her talent at events hosted by Urbaser Sumeet.

Senbagavalli says her steps are simple as she goes in for only those that are easy to master. Her dancing derives its strength from the abandon with which it is done. A post of her dancing with child-like joy in the rain with an Illayaraja and Susheela song in the background has garnered 99K likes. It shows that in dancing heart matter as much as technique, if not more.

But Senbagavalli does not underestimate the relevance of dance techniques.

"I have searched many places for a dance institute that can train me but I am yet to settle on one."

Inter-school quiz competition

Union Christian Matriculation Higher Secondary School in Chetpet will be hosting the 19th edition of its Inter School Quiz Competition 'InQuizitive' for students of classes IX to XII on July 24. Calling all Chennai schools to register using the QR Code on or before July 21, 2026



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Book binding workshop held in Navalur

Eleven pairs of hands came together to create their own personal notebooks at Club Artizen's second OMRt workshop on bookbinding, facilitated by Poornima Palanisamy of The Warmth recently at Wang's Kitchen in Navalur.

The participants, who ranged from a teenager to a grandmother, attended the workshop for a variety of reasons, says a press release.

A. Arani, community resource professional working with 96 SHGs in Injambakkam, attended with five other women to explore whether bookbinding could become a means of livelihood for some of them, while R. Vaishali, proprietor of Bare Knots, a macramé studio, wanted to expand her repertoire.

Anitha Kumari, a school librarian, wanted to understand how she could help her students think about sustainability by creating books using, for instance, unused paper from notebooks.

OMRt is a weekly series of craft workshops aimed at building a community interested in handmade crafts.

Follow Club Artizen on Instagram to stay updated on upcoming OMRt workshops.

Test your knowledge in geography

The Indian National Cartographic Association (INCA), Tamil Nadu chapter, invites school and college students to participate in the Regional and National Quiz Competition. Designed to encourage geographical knowledge, map-reading skills, current affairs, environmental awareness, and an understand-

ing of geospatial technologies, the quiz will offer participants a platform to demonstrate their knowledge while fostering scientific curiosity and teamwork, said a release.

The event will be conducted in two phases: in phase 1, an online quiz would be conducted at the respective schools of the participants; and phase 2 at a



venue in the city.

Registration and participation fee is ₹100. Participant certificate will be provided and first

three prizes will be awarded.

Through workshops, seminars, competitions, and outreach programmes, INCA creates awareness about the importance of maps and geospatial science in education, research, environmental management, disaster mitigation, and sustainable development.

For details, email sujathageobwc@gmail.com or contact P. Sujatha, secretary, INCA Tamil Nadu Chapter at 9840182666

VISTAS starts AI varsity in Thiruvananthapuram

Vel's Institute of Science, Technology and Advanced Studies (VISTAS) opened an Artificial Intelligence (AI) vertical university campus on East Coast Road.

Sridhar Vembu, chief scientist and co-founder of Zoho Corporation, inaugurated the campus in the presence of Ishari K. Ganesh, chancellor, Vel's University, and Ahmed Mir Hashim Khoori, a board member of the Emirates Airline Foundation.

The campus features AI-enabled classrooms, smart learning systems, advanced laboratories, innovation studios, collaborative learning spaces, and digital



libraries.

A major highlight of the campus is its Industry-Academia

Centres of Excellence, established in collaboration with Intel Unnati, TCS iON, Microsoft, and Oracle Academy, which will provide students with hands-on exposure to AI, cloud computing, high-performance computing, and other emerging technologies.

Delivering the inaugural address, Sridhar Vembu appreciated the vision behind the new campus and emphasised the importance of building indigenous technologies.

He encouraged students to develop deep technical expertise, embrace lifelong learning, solve real-world problems

through innovation, and contribute meaningfully to India's technological advancement.

A Memorandum of Understanding was signed between Vel's University and the Dubai Airlines Group for aviation training, internships, faculty exchange, skill development, and international career opportunities for students.

The varsity will also soon sign an MoU with Zoho Corporation to collaborate in Artificial Intelligence, emerging technologies, research, innovation, entrepreneurship, skill development, and industry-academia initiatives, added the release.

Exhibition of silk saris in Anna Nagar

D. Ravi Silks is holding a silk expo at Kanchi Residency, Anna Nagar, featuring exquisite silk saris combining authenticity and quality.

D Ravi began his career in 1987 as a weaver. Later, he

started a small enterprise with six weavers at his home. In 1998, he opened a store in Kancheepuram.

The showroom designs and weaves a variety of Kancheepuram silk saris, with traditional designs inspired

by Kancheepuram's temples and the dreams of present-generation women.

The saris woven by more than 250 weavers reflect timeless elegance, exceptional craftsmanship, and the rich heritage of Kancheepuram silk, said a release.

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Preventive Lung Health Screening

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